

As a result, the immediate future, or dare we say the requirement of EVs is for short-distance intracity travel. Even with sparse charging infrastructure, this sort of reality feels somewhat doable. How the EV adoption fares in this specific use case will determine its distant future.

WHAT ABOUT OTHER OPTIONS?

We mentioned sparse charging infrastructure so EV hybrids can be a great middle-of-the-road solution to combat the same. A self-charging hybrid is independent of charging infrastructure and still provides a dedicated EV mode for driving within the city. Since it also has a petrol engine, going a long distance with it is as easy as any other IC car.

We recently tested the Honda City e:HEV, which is an EV Hybrid and we were thoroughly impressed by it. The quick acceleration of the EV motor combined with the long-hauling capabilities of the petrol engine left us impressed. However, its pricing is something that'll ultimately deter a lot of users.

In addition to the cost of the Hybrid tech, the reason for the new City's high price tag is the inclusion of the various Honda Sensing safety driving assist features. For a country like India, we truly believe the City was better without them. Even an option for a lower and more bare-bones trim with just a hybrid powertrain would've made the City more accessible. And we think there's an important lesson to learn here.

For EVs to become mainstream, manufacturers need to stop treating them as a technical showcase and show them as rugged, reliable, and more importantly affordable electric vehicles. Right now most OEMs are trying to run before they can walk. Although we do see the appeal in selling an overpriced, feature-loaded EV, a lot of people would much rather prefer a simpler machine.

EV AFFORDABILITY

Our criticism of EVs being a technical showcase also feeds into the fact that it makes such vehicles more out of the reach of the common man. We



do agree that a battery represents 40-50 per cent of the total cost of an EV but adding more high-tech electronics does not help the situation either. Moreover, for EVs to reach price parity, the components inside them need to change. As of right now, Lithium is getting more expensive and it is highly unlikely to come down in price any time soon. Therefore a radical development in manufacturing EV batteries from a more sustainable and widely available raw material is the only sure shot way to bring the price of EVs down in the long run.

With a global supply chain disruption in the background and a chip shortage that shows no sign of slowing down, it's pretty hard to predict when EVs will reach price parity with petrol-powered cars. As mentioned above, the immediate relief in EV prices can come from a redefined design approach in which automotive manufacturers focus their attention on releasing a bare-bones EV with more range instead of one loaded with more futuristic connectivity and driver-assist features.

WHAT WILL HAPPEN TO THE OLDER STUFF?

If we'd be replacing the old (ICE vehicles) with the new (EVs), we'd eventually have to answer the question, what'll happen to all cars that roam the streets worldwide today? Environment preservation is the sole reason for EVs to exist in the first place, therefore it must be the first

consideration in every step forward in this grand plan. It's here where we think the word "Repurposing" must take huge precedence.

A number of retro-fitment companies have sprung up all around Europe recently. In the United States as well, companies like the Electrified Garage, offer retro-fitment services to give new life to old ICE and Electric vehicles alike. And it is here where we see the potential for a greener tomorrow.

Regardless of what any fluff marketing piece from an automotive manufacturer says, the best way to preserve the environment is simply to buy less. Buying new EVs in droves and replacing every single one of our petrol vehicles with an EV will only worsen the environment we've pledged to protect. And in the far future when ICE vehicles begin to die out, replacing their internals with a zero-emission battery kit will ultimately shift a huge chunk of the population on this planet to EVs. While saving billions of tons in carbon emissions at the same time.

So the future of EVs is multifaceted. Just like how every car today is not strictly a petrol car; as we have diesel-powered and CNG-powered vehicles, in the future we will most probably see not just fully electric vehicles but also hybrids and even hydrogen-powered cars, once we figure out its logistics. It is as we mentioned before. Various shades of grey. 